

Open and Distance Learning as a Tool for Inclusive Higher Education in Sri Lanka: Opportunities and Challenges

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Introduction and Background

- Higher education is a fundamental driver of social inclusion, economic development, and lifelong learning.
- Open and Distance Learning (ODL) has become a key strategy for expanding educational opportunities.
- Following the COVID-19 pandemic, Sri Lankan universities increasingly integrated digital learning into teaching and learning.
- ODL enables learning beyond geographical and time constraints, offering opportunities for students from diverse backgrounds.

Research Problem & Objectives

Research Problem

- Although ODL expands access to higher education, its contribution to inclusive education remains uncertain.

Research Gap

- Previous research → online learning and technology adoption
- Limited attention to ODL + inclusive higher education
- Limited focus on both students and lecturers
- Need to understand opportunities and challenges

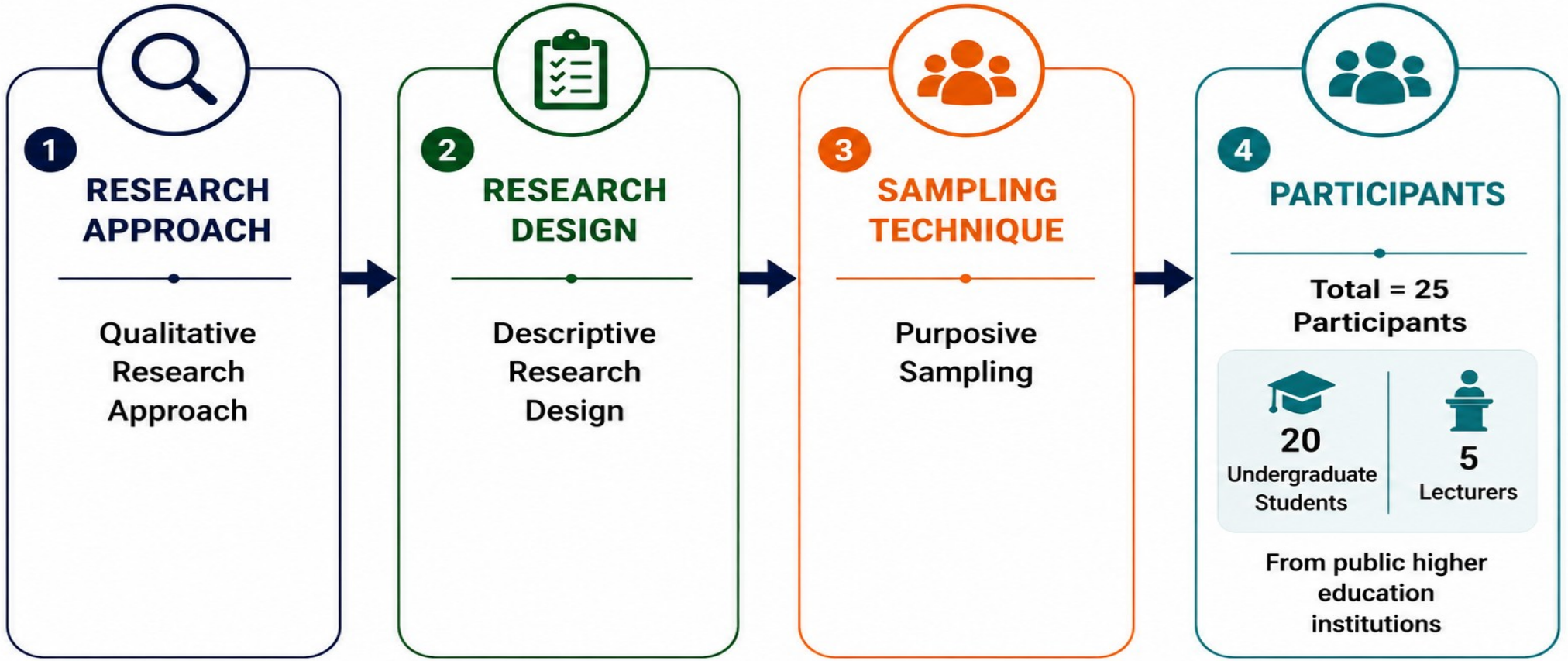
Main Objective

- To explore the role of ODL as a tool for promoting inclusive higher education in Sri Lanka.

Specific Areas

- Explore the opportunities of ODL for inclusive higher education.
- Identify the challenges experienced by students and lecturers.
- Recommend strategies for improving inclusive digital learning

Research Methodology



Data Collection and Analysis

5 DATA COLLECTION

Semi-Structured Interviews

Participants: 25 respondents
- 20 Undergraduate Students
- 5 Lecturers

Interview Duration:
30–45 minutes per participant

Mode:
Face-to-face interviews

Ethical Considerations:
- Informed consent obtained before interviews
- Confidentiality and anonymity ensured
- Participation was voluntary
- Participants had the right to withdraw at any stage

6 DATA ANALYSIS

Braun & Clarke's (2006) Six-Phase Thematic Analysis

1. **Familiarization with the Data**
   Reading interview transcripts repeatedly to gain an overall understanding.
2. **Generating Initial Codes**
   Identifying meaningful statements and assigning preliminary codes.
3. **Searching for Themes**
   Grouping similar codes into broader categories and potential themes.
4. **Reviewing Themes**
   Checking the consistency and relevance of themes against the coded data.
5. **Defining and Naming Themes**
   Refining themes and assigning clear, descriptive names.
6. **Producing the Report**
   Interpreting findings and presenting themes with supporting participant quotations.

Findings: Opportunities

1. Flexible Learning

- Time and location flexibility
- Supports students with personal commitments

2. Enhanced Digital Skills

- Improved technological competence

3. Greater Access to Learning Resources

- Wider range of online educational materials

Findings: Challenges

1. Poor Internet Connectivity
- Interrupted learning
- Missed lectures

2. Reduced Learner Engagement
- Passive participation
- Difficulty maintaining interaction

3. Limited Institutional Support
- Technical infrastructure
- Training and support

Discussion

- ODL expands access to higher education through flexibility and increased availability of learning resources.
- However, digital inequalities such as poor connectivity and limited institutional support continue to hinder inclusive participation.
- The findings suggest that technology alone cannot ensure inclusive education; meaningful inclusion requires equitable access, digital literacy, and learner-centred teaching.
- Therefore, strengthening digital infrastructure and institutional support is essential to maximize the inclusive potential of ODL.

Recommendations

Universities

- Strengthen digital infrastructure
- Improve Learning Management Systems
- Provide continuous technical support

Lecturers

- Adopt learner-centred teaching
- Increase interaction
- Encourage collaborative learning

Students

- Improve digital literacy
- Develop self-directed learning skills

Conclusion

- Open and Distance Learning (ODL) has significant potential to promote inclusive higher education by improving flexibility, accessibility, and learning opportunities.
- However, challenges such as digital inequality, limited institutional support, and reduced learner engagement continue to affect meaningful participation.
- The success of ODL depends on strengthening digital infrastructure, enhancing digital literacy, and adopting learner-centred teaching practices.
- Ultimately, inclusive higher education requires not only access to technology but also equitable opportunities for all students to participate, engage, and succeed.

"Technology can expand access to education, but only equitable access, meaningful participation, and strong institutional support can achieve truly inclusive higher education."

Thank you for your attention.